

The Global Burden of Mental Illness:

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions, their disease burden, and the persistent gap between need and treatment.

Global data, 2023. Source: Our World
in Data / IHME.

Hundreds of Millions Affected: 1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major Depression

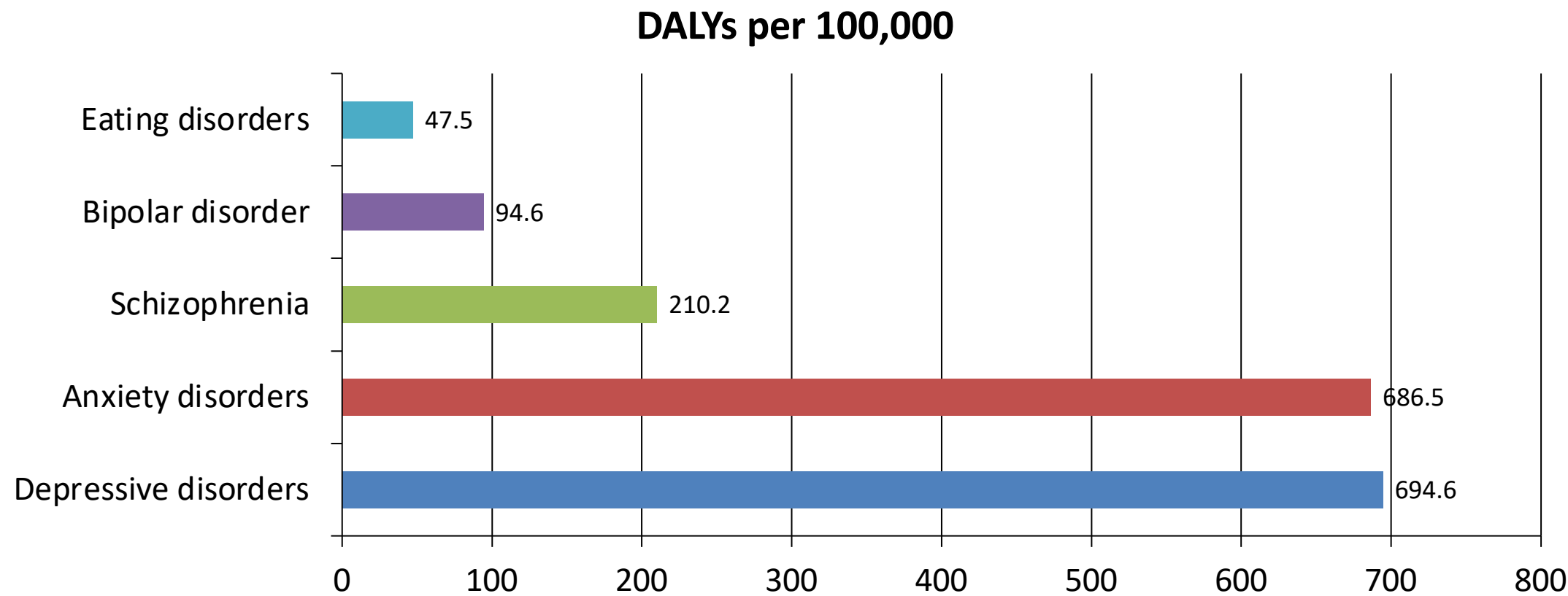
1 in 3

1 in 5

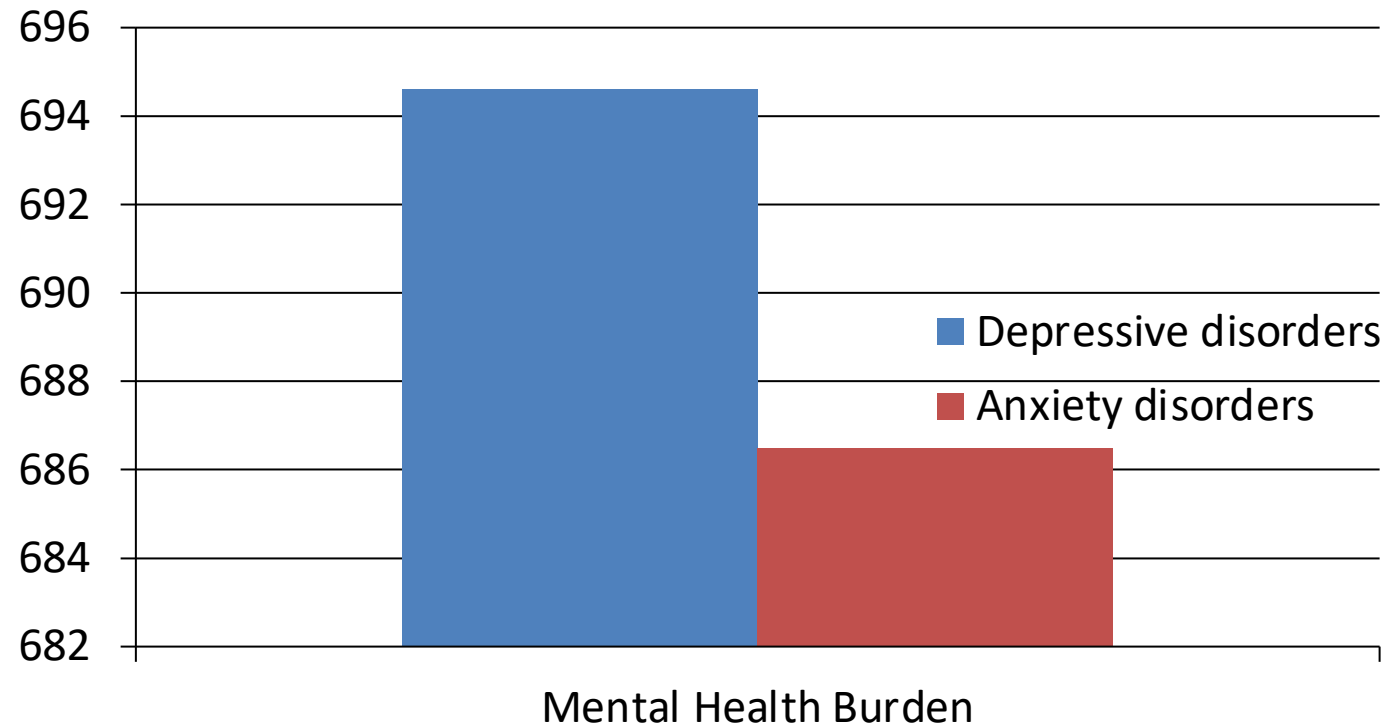
Women experience major depression in their lifetime. Men experience major depression in their lifetime.

from common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar). Addressing this burden is a critical

Depression and Anxiety Dominate: ~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K Respectively

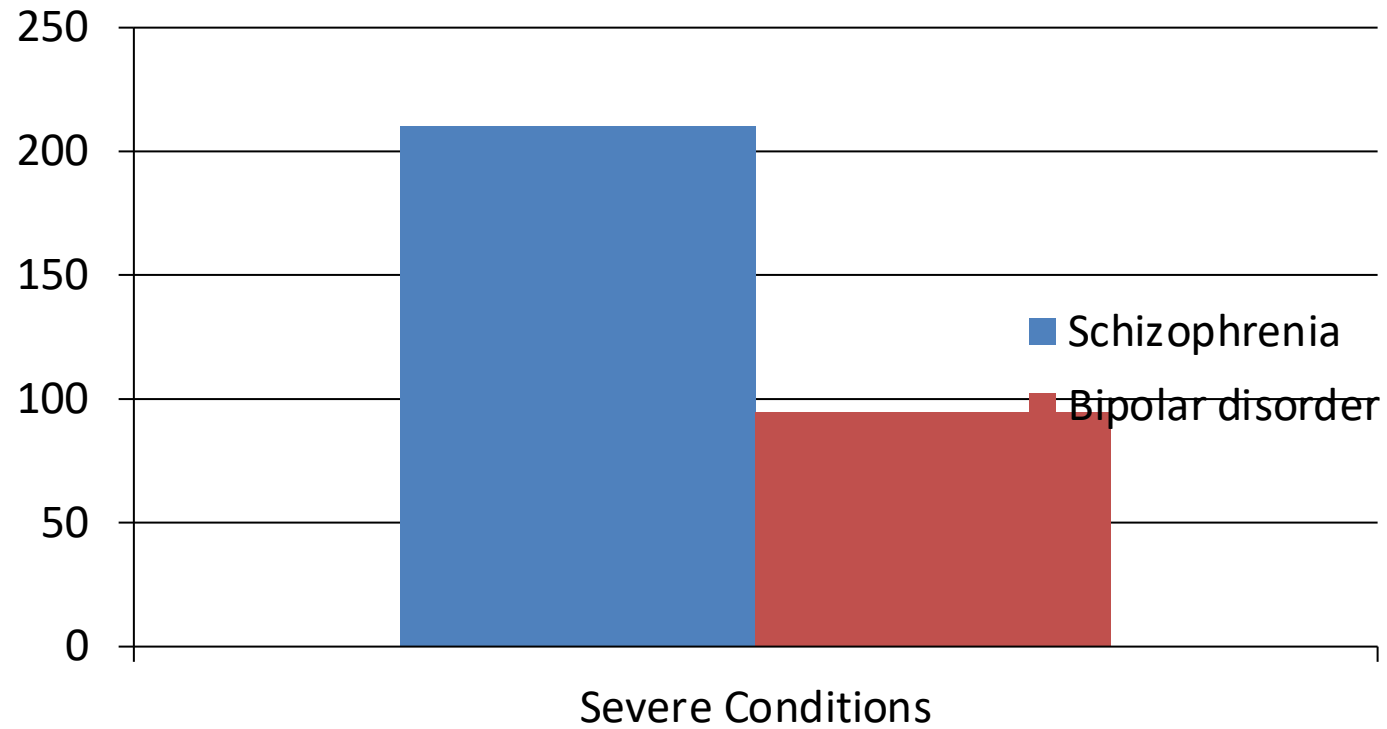


Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide



r, depression and anxiety account for ~80% of the total mental health burden across these top categories, dwarfing the

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact



is lower than depression and anxiety, the individual severity and disability associated with schizophrenia and bipolar d

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Stigma

Many hide symptoms due to discomfort and fear of judgment.

Access

Significant lack of treatment in low- and middle-income countries.

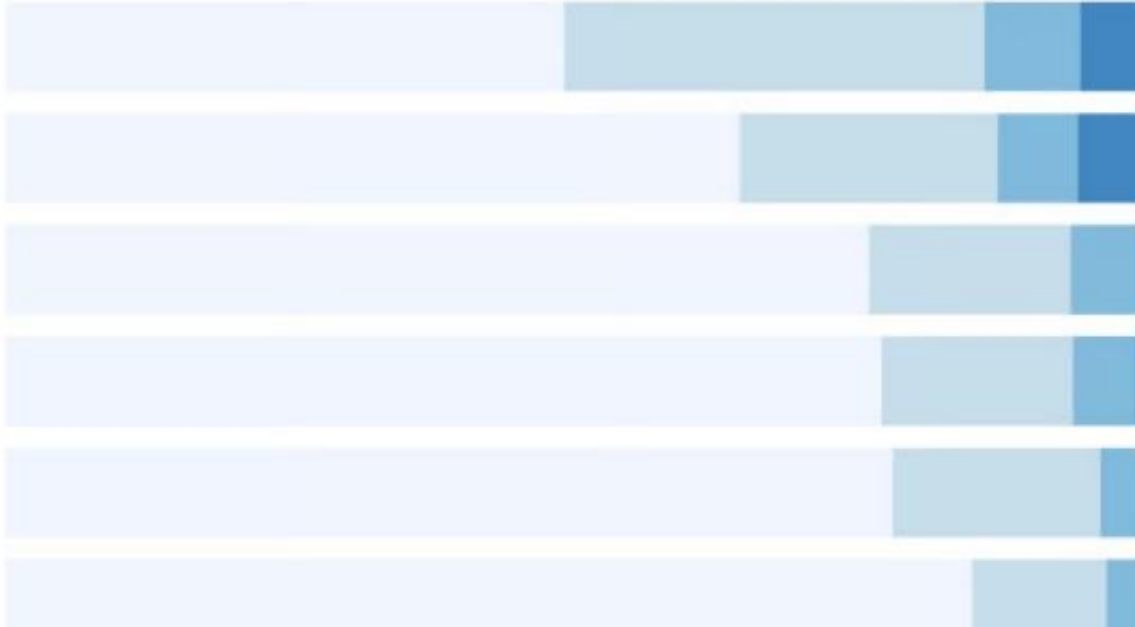
Quality

Available treatment is frequently of poor quality.

Underreporting

Stigma leads to hidden prevalence, masking the true burden.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations



Diverse Coping Strategies:

- Taking prescribed medication (common in higher-income settings)
- Engaging in religious or spiritual activities (prevalent globally)
- Talking to friends or family (widely reported social support)

Responses vary widely by culture, economy, and healthcare system, requiring tailored rather than one-size-fits-all policy interventions.

Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs (~80% across top categories).
- Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden and require specialized, intensive care.
- Effective treatment exists, but access and quality remain vastly inadequate globally.
- Stigma acts as a double burden: suppressing help-seeking behaviors and skewing accurate prevalence data via underreporting.
- Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining critical care for severe conditions.